I DON'T WEAR A watch to tell the time. I wear it as an object," American artist Andy Warhol had famously said. The said object—a watch—has become an object of desire, and India, a desirable inspiration and a booming market. Swiss luxury watchmaker Jacob & Co.'s latest India-exclusive limited-edition timepiece is a telling example of how seriously global watch brands are taking the Indian market. Unveiled in September 2026, the Epic X Mahadev Edition draws inspiration from Lord Shiva, incorporating his imagery alongside the *trishul*, *damru*, and the Om symbol into the watch's intricate skeletonised dial. Housed in a 44-mm titanium case, and priced at ₹35.88 lakh, the mechanical watch is available exclusively through watch retailer Ethos.

This is not the first time the luxury watchmaker has turned to Indian culture for inspiration. Its earlier limited editions of Ram Janmabhoomi (49 pieces at ₹34 lakh each) and Sher-e-Punjab (22 pieces in 18k rose gold at ₹84 lakh each) celebrated religious and cultural identities through elaborate designs.

For an industry long accustomed to Indian collectors travelling abroad to buy its coveted timepieces, India is increasingly becoming a market that global watchmakers cannot afford to overlook.

The numbers explain why. According to the Federation of the Swiss Watch Industry, Swiss watch exports, during the first six months of 2026, declined 0.7% globally to CHF 12.8 billion. Shipments to the US fell 14.8% and China, 5%.

India, however, moved in the opposite direction. Swiss watch exports to the country surged 31.5% during January-June 2026, reaching a total import value of CHF168.7 million (approx. ₹1,991 crore), making it one of the industry's fastest-growing markets. India imported 200,000 Swiss watches during this period, a nearly 37% increase year-on-year.



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India's overall watch market is estimated at around $4.19 billion, according to Mordor Intelligence's report 'India Watch Market' and likely to increase to $7.52 billion by 2031. While affordable and mid-range watches continue to account for a substantial part of the market, the premium end is expanding rapidly. Mordor Intelligence expects premium models to rise by 11.54% CAGR between 2025-31. A June 2026 HDFC Securities report estimates the wider ₹1 lakh to ₹10 lakh watch segment at approximately ₹6,500 crore. These estimates,

The Swiss Connection

200,000
SWISS WATCHES IMPORTED BY INDIA DURING JAN-JUNE 2026

31.5%
GROWTH IN SWISS WATCH EXPORTS DURING JAN-JUNE 2026

CHF168.7 MN
IMPORT VALUE OF SWISS WATCHES DURING JAN-JUNE 2026

SOURCE FEDERATION OF THE SWISS WATCH INDUSTRY